

Gramsci and the turn to hegemony

Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937) was an Italian Marxist writing in the context of early 20th-century Europe, marked by mass politics, failed socialist revolutions in Western Europe, and the rise of fascism. His work emerged from a central problem in Marxism: why capitalist societies secured popular stability despite deep inequality. Gramsci wrote most of his theory in prison under Mussolini, producing the Prison Notebooks, which focus on culture, ideology, and power rather than economic determinism alone.

Hegemony

Hegemony refers to the way a dominant social group maintains power primarily through consent rather than coercion. For Gramsci, ruling groups succeed when their values, beliefs, and interests are accepted as common sense by society as a whole. Hegemony is cultural and moral leadership, not just political control, and it must be continuously produced and renewed.

Hegemony and Consent

At the heart of Gramsci's contribution is the concept of hegemony. Hegemony refers to the way a dominant social group maintains power not primarily through force, but through consent. This is a crucial shift. Power, for Gramsci, does not operate only through the state, the police, or the military.

Hegemony involves the more or less active consent of large sections of the population. Hegemony does not designate a particular ideology or even the ruling ideas in society but rather a process of management and administration. Hegemony is not something imposed on society from above so much as generated from below.

Culture is not a passive reflection of economic power, but an active terrain of struggle. Newspapers, films, television, education, and everyday language all play a role in shaping how people understand the world.

Common Sense and Good Sense

Common sense is the everyday, taken-for-granted set of beliefs through which people understand the world. It is historically produced, often contradictory, and shaped by dominant groups.

Good sense refers to the critical and reflective elements within common sense that can challenge dominant ideas. Hegemonic struggle involves shaping common sense while suppressing or marginalising good sense.

Gramsci defines intellectuals broadly as those who organise ideas and meaning in society.

Traditional intellectuals see themselves as neutral or independent.

Organic intellectuals emerge from specific social groups and articulate their interests.

Media professionals (journalists, editors, cultural producers) can function as organic intellectuals by shaping narratives, values, and social norms.

Media as a Site of Hegemonic Struggle

From a Gramscian perspective, media does not simply transmit information; it constructs reality through framing, representation, and repetition.

Media normalises particular explanations of social issues (for example, individual responsibility over structural causes), helping to stabilise hegemonic common sense while managing dissent within acceptable limits.

Hall applied Gramsci's theories in his own analysis – as well as incorporating elements of structuralism,